

Puerto Rico And Its Relationship With The United States [C1]

È uno Stato libero associato agli Stati Uniti: ha una propria costituzione e leader eletti, ma Washington controlla la difesa e la politica estera.

More than one hundred years after the United States took Puerto Rico from Spain, the island is still dealing with its position as a US territory and the long-lasting effects of colonialism. Puerto Rico has faced many [hardships](#), including a weak economy, hurricanes, and population loss. Today, the question of whether Puerto Rico should become a US state is still very important and widely debated.

RISING UP

Before Europeans arrived, Puerto Rico was home to the Taíno, who were the Indigenous people of the Greater Antilles and the surrounding islands of The Bahamas, Cuba, Dominican Republic, Haiti, and Jamaica. They named the island Boriquén and lived in small villages led by a chief, called a cacique. Christopher Columbus reached the island in 1493 during his second voyage and [claimed](#) it for Spain. For the next four hundred years, Spain controlled Puerto Rico. The island became an important centre for growing and exporting [sugarcane](#), coffee, and tobacco. Over time, Puerto Ricans became unhappy with Spanish [rule](#) and started to demand more freedom.

US RULE

In 1897, Puerto Rico [inched towards](#) limited self-[rule](#): the island's Autonomist Party [secured](#) a [charter granting](#) the island a degree of political autonomy. Although the new government had its own institutions, it remained subject to the authority of the Spanish governor-general, who represented the Spanish Crown. This brief experiment in self-government ended abruptly the following year. During the Spanish-American War, US forces invaded Puerto Rico on 25 July 1898. Many Puerto Ricans initially

welcomed the change in sovereignty, hopeful that US [rule](#) would bring political stability and economic development. In 1917, Congress passed the Jones [Act](#), which created a local Senate and House of Representatives and gave Puerto Ricans US citizenship. After World War Two, as many countries gained independence, the United States faced pressure to give Puerto Rico more control over its own affairs. In 1952, the island officially became the [Commonwealth of Puerto Rico](#).

SOVEREIGNTY

To find out more, Speak Up contacted Dr. Lorrin Thomas, a historian from Rutgers University specialising in the 20th century Americas, and who has written *Puerto Rican Citizen: History and Political Identity in Twentieth Century New York City*. We started by asking her how Puerto Rico's identity has been [shaped](#) by its relationship with the US. **Dr. Lorrin Thomas (American accent):** There have been people in Puerto Rico since the very beginning of US [rule](#), since 1898, who were interested in being affiliated with the US. Since 1898, Puerto Ricans have debated how best to achieve the original goals that they went to war with Spain over, which was achieving some degree of sovereignty. Most people who were involved in that fight with Spain wanted [outright independence](#). That was the goal. And initially, it seemed that the United States was going to [trounce](#) Spain, and there was [were] some reasonable assumptions all around that the US would honour this fight for independence because it resembled what people in the United States, the colonists, had gone through with Britain the century before.

Entertainment

Bad Bunny: Puerto Rican Global Superstar È stato l'artista più ascoltato nel 2025. La sua musica, influenzata dallo stile portoricano, è un simbolo di rivendicazione delle proprie origini. Sarah Davison, Melita Cameron-Wood

AFFILIATION TO A SUPERPOWER

The situation quickly grew complicated, and the question of Puerto Rico's political future became a debate that has lasted for more than a century.

Early hopes for independence met competing visions of [statehood](#) and proposals for a [middle path](#) that balanced self-government with [ties](#) to the United States. **Dr. Lorrin Thomas:** The US was a new global superpower, and so some of the people who had in the late 19th century supported independence began exploring the possibility of some relationship with the United States that would involve perhaps self-determination to some degree, but also affiliation with this great economy and global superpower. The details, of course, are very different now than they were a hundred years ago, but the range of political positions is quite similar. So this debate over [statehood](#) versus independence versus something in between has been going on for over a century.

TAXATION WITHOUT REPRESENTATION

Puerto Rico's political status within the United States is often [summed up](#) by the phrase "taxation without representation." Puerto Ricans are subject to federal laws and many federal taxes, can be [drafted](#) into the US military, and are governed by decisions made in Washington. [Yet](#) they have no voting representation in Congress and cannot vote for the President while living on the island. This imbalance, of obligations without full political power, captures the [core](#) frustration behind [ongoing](#) debates about Puerto Rico's status. **Dr. Lorrin Thomas:** There were a series of legislative moves in the US Congress starting in the 1970s that set Puerto Rico up to be vulnerable. So that by the time the global financial crisis hit in 2008, Puerto Rico was already weakened in terms of its [revenues](#) and its ability to [withstand](#) any economic [downturn](#). And then the hurricanes of 2017, which were major and terrible... Puerto Rico's been through a number of major and terrible hurricanes before, but it was the economic destabilization that had happened a decade earlier that caused the total crisis on the island. I am certain that a large proportion of the representatives in Congress are totally uninterested in Puerto Rico. I mean, it seems tiny and insignificant to many people unless their districts contain a notable number of Puerto Rican migrants or people of Puerto Rican descent who care about the island and care about what's going on there and have family there, et cetera. The representation for the island in the US Congress is one representative who's called a resident

commissioner who can vote on [bills](#) in certain committees but cannot cast a vote on a final bill. So, essentially, it is an example of taxation without representation. Puerto Ricans do pay Social Security tax, they pay taxes for Medicare and other [benefits](#). They just don't pay federal [income tax](#). They pay instead a [pretty hefty](#) tax to the Commonwealth. There's all kinds of ways that Puerto Ricans contribute to the federal tax base of the United States, and yet they don't have representation in Congress.

GLOBAL FINANCIAL CRISIS

Puerto Rico's economic destabilization [stemmed](#) from federal policies that [eroded](#) revenue and limited growth. The [phase-out](#) of tax incentives and the loss of its manufacturing base left the island dependent on [debt](#), while rising unemployment and declining investment weakened its economy. By the 2008 financial crisis, Puerto Rico was already fragile, leaving it [poorly equipped](#) to recover from disasters like the 2017 hurricanes. **Dr. Lorrin Thomas:** Puerto Rico's great industrial boom that was supposed to have [lifted](#) it into almost first-world status after World War Two had not really materialised in the way that its [boosters](#) had promised. So during this period of [downturn](#) in the mid-70s, the US Congress wanted to [bolster](#) the Puerto Rican economy by [enabling](#) businesses to profit without paying taxes on their [revenues](#). The United States [Internal Revenue](#) Code, the tax code, was [amended](#), and one part of that amendment involved exempting American companies who wanted to establish a business in Puerto Rico so they didn't have to pay [income tax](#) on their [revenues](#). So that produced a new kind of slow economic boost. In the mid-80s, the [bankruptcy code](#) was [amended](#) and a [provision](#) was added that excluded Puerto Rico from having the protections of bankruptcy [rules](#). US [cities](#), if they're experiencing some kind of economic crisis — I mean, Detroit is a [fairly](#) recent example in the United States —, they can [resort](#) to bankruptcy restructuring that will enable them basically to manage [debts](#) and make decisions that will enable these public services and infrastructure to continue to survive. But Puerto Rico was excluded from those [rules](#). In the mid-90s, Congress decided to phase out the tax credits that had been established in the 1970s. Over a couple of years, the couple of years that happened to precede immediately the

financial crisis in 2008, the island's economy lost hundreds of millions of dollars in revenue. And as this financial hit was being felt, and as [public utilities](#) started really struggling in the 2010s, they could not [resort](#) to bankruptcy restructuring or the kinds of protections that an entity, a city, in the United States could [rely on](#). So this precipitated a really major crisis that was already happening before 2008. And then the global financial crisis hit the island exceptionally hard.

THE GRITO DE LARES FLAG

The Grito de Lares flag is an important symbol of Puerto Rican pride and resistance that originated during an early revolt against Spanish [rule](#) in 1868. It consists of a large white cross that divides the flag in four equal rectangles, two blue above and two red below. In the top left corner stands a five-pointed white star. The white star [stands for](#) liberty and freedom, the blue rectangle for the sky and waters of the island, the red rectangles for the blood [spilled](#) by the heroes of the revolt, and the white cross for the [yearning](#) of homeland redemption. In 1895, the Puerto Rican section of the Cuban Revolutionary Party, who were exiled in New York City at the time, replaced the Lares flag with the current flag of Puerto Rico. As pro-independence movements grew in the Caribbean under Spanish [rule](#), many Cuban and Puerto Rican activists chose to leave for the US. The design of the current flag of Puerto Rico is based on the Cuban flag, with a [switch](#) of the red and blue colors. The Cuban flag itself was inspired by the United States flag, using similar colors, [stripes](#) and a single white star on a [bold](#) background. The red [stripes](#) and three corners of the triangle represent the legislative, executive, and judicial [branches](#) of the government, while the star [stands for](#) the commonwealth and the white [stripes](#) represent human rights and the freedom of the individual. The flag was officially recognized on 25 July 1952 when Puerto Rico established its commonwealth status. If you want to know more about this topic, read the article [Puerto Rico: Disaster, Neglect, And The Fight For Statehood](#).

Glossary

- **granting** = concedere
- **Act** = legge
- **downturn** = recessione
- **bills** = progetti di legge
- **stemmed** = derivare da
- **enabling** = consentire
- **provision** = clausola
- **resort** = ricorrere
- **trounce** = sconfiggere
- **withstand** = resistere
- **phase-out** = eliminazione graduale
- **lifted** = sollevare
- **public utilities** = servizi pubblici
- **rely on** = fare affidamento su
- **hardships** = difficoltà
- **shaped** = plasmare
- **revenues** = entrate
- **boosters** = sostenitori
- **switch** = scambio
- **branches** = rami, poteri
- **Yet** = tuttavia
- **debt** = debito
- **bolster** = rafforzare
- **stands for** = rappresentare
- **bold** = sgargiante
- **benefits** = benefici
- **income tax** = imposta sul reddito
- **claimed** = rivendicare
- **sugarcane** = canna da zucchero
- **rule** = dominio
- **inched towards** = avvicinarsi gradualmente
- **charter** = statuto
- **Commonwealth of Puerto Rico** = Stato Libero Associato di Porto Rico

- **secured** = ottenere
- **middle path** = via di mezzo
- **ties** = vincoli
- **summed up** = riassumere
- **eroded** = erodere
- **poorly equipped** = poco attrezzato
- **Internal Revenue** = agenzia delle entrate
- **amended** = emendare
- **statehood** = status di Stato
- **drafted** = arruolare
- **ongoing** = in corso
- **pretty hefty** = piuttosto consistente
- **bankruptcy code** = codice fallimentare
- **spilled** = versare
- **yearning** = desiderio
- **stripes** = strisce
- **self-rule** = autogoverno
- **outright independence** = indipendenza totale
- **core** = principale
- **fairly** = abbastanza